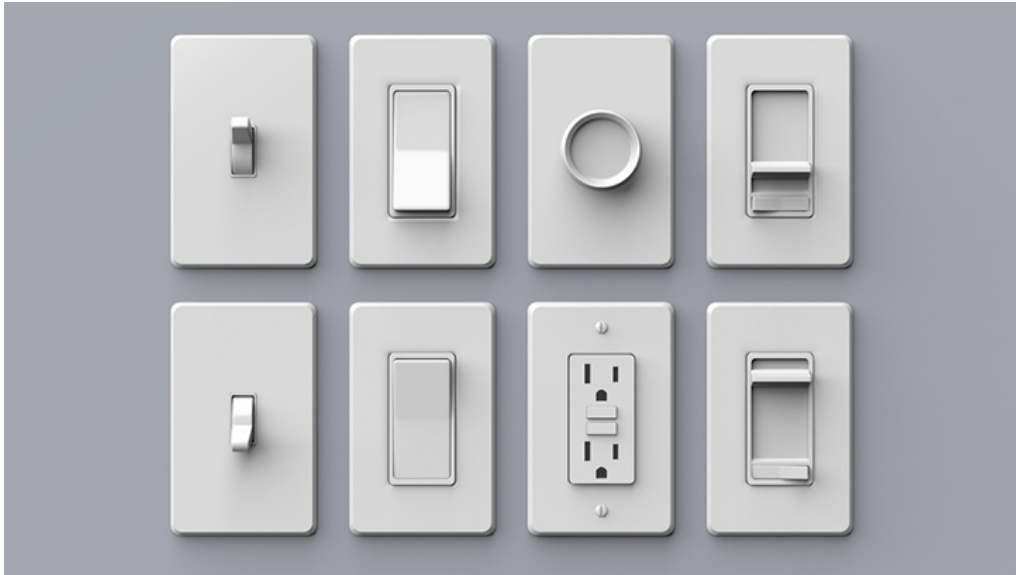


How to Install a Dimmer Switch

By: Chaz Wilke - Staff Writer



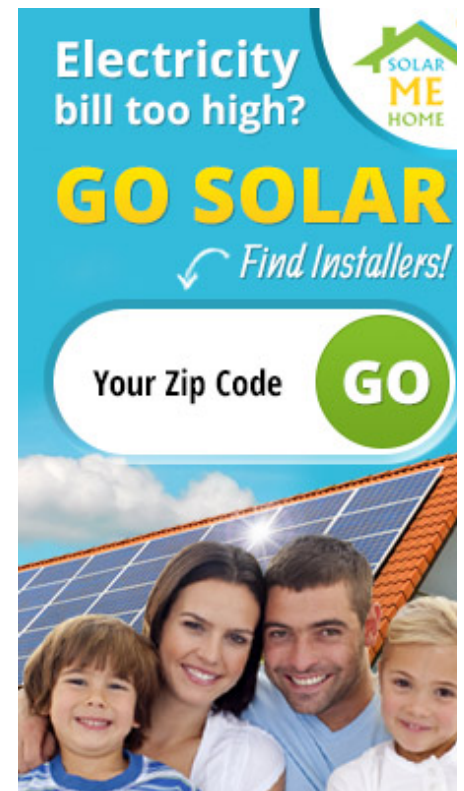
You've settled in to your dream home. You've chosen the wall colors for each room, you've hung your new curtains and you are in love with your new space. But, there is one nagging issue left to deal with. That blinding light pouring out of the ceiling fixture in your bedroom has got to go.

Instead of never using this light, consider installing a dimmer switch.

Installing a dimmer switch is one of the more common DIY upgrades a homeowner can undertake. It should be stressed that **dealing with electrical wires is dangerous and a potentially deadly endeavor**. But if performed correctly, this project should be easy for even the novice do-it-yourselfer.

Step-by-Step Walkthrough

1. The first and most important step is to **turn off the power** that feeds into the switch. You should have access to your circuit breaker or fuse box somewhere in the house. You should see a number of large switches, each relating to a specific circuit running through your home. Find the circuit that includes the wall switch that you want to change and shut it off.
2. Be sure to **test the switch** before removal. Flip the switch on and off to make sure the power is off to that light. This is very important, because the electricity running through a wall switch can lead to serious injury and potentially death if you were to get shocked by a live wire.



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3. Remove the switch's cover plate with a flathead screwdriver. There should be two screws, one above and one below the switch. Paint may have fused the cover plate to the wall, so removing the screws may fail to loosen the plate. If this is the case, wedge the flathead screwdriver between the cover plate and the wall and pop the plate off.

4. Remove the switch box from the wall's electrical box. There will be two more screws beneath the cover plate, one above and one below the switch. Once these screws are removed, carefully pull the switch box out of the wall a few inches.



5. You'll see three wires attached to the switch box. There will be one black, one white (or potentially two black), and one ground wire which might be bare copper wire or could be wrapped in green wire insulation. **Disconnect those three wires** from the switch box. Be sure to **unscrew the ground wire last**.

6. Cut and strip insulation from the three wires. You will want straight, clean wires, with about an inch of bare wire on the end of each one.

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7. Now **wrap each wall wire to the dimmer switch wire of the same color**. Use a pair of needle nose pliers to make sure the connection is tight. Then cap each pair of exposed twisted wires with a wire nut. Be sure to twist the wire nut tight so it won't fall off inside the wall.

8. Remember to **check that all exposed wire is covered by a wire nut**.

9. Carefully **push the wires back into the wall's electrical box**. Make sure there's no strain on any of the wires and they are resting naturally inside the box.

10. **Push the switch's box into the wall's electrical box**. Again, make sure you don't force the switch back into the wall. Make sure that everything is resting without any strain on the wires.

11. **Screw the dimmer switch into the wall's electrical box**. One screw above and one screw below.

12. **Screw the cover plate back onto the wall**.

13. **Turn on the circuit** that you turned off earlier.

14. **Test the switch**. Flip on the light and dim your ceiling fixture.

15. **Take pride** in your newfound control over your room's illumination!

Bonus Walk-through Video

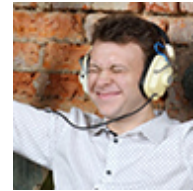
If you're a visual learner, take a look at this YouTube walkthrough of the same process outlined above:

How to Install a Dimmer Switch



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